Pearson Edexcel

Examiners' Report
Principal Examiner Feedback

Summer 2024

Pearson Edexcel International Award in Lower Secondary Computing
Paper 1 (LCP11_01)

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Introduction

This is an untiered paper that has been specifically designed so that easier questions are more prevalent earlier in the paper, becoming progressively more difficult later on. This paper has been designed to be accessible, so that students of all ability ranges will find questions that are both challenging and interesting throughout. Students will find that 'command words' are used consistently in the paper to indicate the type of response expected.

Successful students often provided more detailed responses, providing more than just simple statements, including examples and reasons where expansions or explanations were required.

Students should develop their use of subject-specific and technical language, and avoid giving generic responses, responding in the context of the question.

Question 1

Most candidates suggested 'making their accounts private' and therefore this would limit who information is shared with. They frequently gave examples of the type of information that should not be posted. There were examples of the other mark points in candidates' responses, however MP1 and MP4 were the most common mark points awarded. It is important that students are clear about what the question is asking and relate their response to the context given. Creating strong passwords, was not relevant to the context of staying safe when using social media.

Question 2 (c)

Responses to this question varied. Candidates need to be clear it is the devices that connect to the network that can be portable, rather than the network itself. Candidates should be encouraged to qualify responses such as cheaper and easier, for example cheaper to set up.

Question 3

This was generally answered well, and the majority gave 'GPS' as their response, followed by CCTV.

Question 7 (a)

Some candidates were able to state that a modem converted signals, with some specifying that it converted between analogue and digital signals. However, some candidates confused a modem with different items of hardware used to connect devices on a / to a network. It is important that candidates can state the purpose of the different network devices identified on the specification.

Question 7 (b)

Few candidates gave response that extended far enough to suggest collaboration, although documents can be shared on the network, it doesn't necessarily mean there is collaboration – by editing those shared documents or that they are being stored centrally. The most common correct response tended to relate to virtual meetings.

Question 8

Many candidates were able to explain the role of an input device. Incorrect responses tended to identify an input device, rather that stating its role. Some responses described an output device.

Question 10 (d)

Many candidates identified the points identified in the mark scheme. Where candidates failed to achieve the mark, they had identified a type of malware, rather than anti-malware, or they had identified a software manufacturer. This couldn't be awarded as often companies can manufacture different types of software and not just anti-malware.

Question 13 (a)

Responses were varied for this question. Many were able to identify one way to improve the binary representation of sound. However, there were a number of candidates that referred to terms relating to images, such as colour depth, rather than bit depth. Other incorrect responses talked about increasing the pitch / height of the wave.

Question 13 (b)

Responses were varied for this question. Most candidates referred to how pixels made up a bitmap image, rather than how colour is represented. Candidates were able to explain that it involved binary / bits, but then were unable to relate that to colour – either the number of colours represented or the colour that is being represented by the binary pattern.

Question 15 (b)

There were few incorrect responses and few occasions where candidates left the response blank. About half of the responses where the mark was awarded correctly identified 'answer' as the variable. Those that identified 'points' were awarded the mark at this level, but it is important to note that this is the identifier for an array in the extract of code given.

Question 15 (c)

It is important that candidates understand the difference between assignment operator (=), comparison operators (<, <=, ==, >=, >, !=), Boolean operators (AND, OR, NOT) and arithmetic operators (+, -, *, /). Where candidates understood this, they tended to identify that the purpose of the * operator was to multiply. Where candidates identified the purpose incorrectly, they had identified the = as an arithmetic operator.

Question 17 (b)

Although attempted by most, few candidates answered this question correctly. Many just re-wrote the code or just wrote the final output. Candidates should be encouraged to trace a program through, practical examples of doing this and then creating the code to show it happening to support their understanding would be beneficial.

Question 19 (a)

Candidates were frequently able to correctly label 'Yes' and 'No' from the first decision box. They tended to mix up the labels on the second decision box. Few candidates correctly drew an arrow line from the process box to the correct position between the process box labelled 'Set index to 0' and the first decision box.

Question 19 (b)

Some candidates did not attempt a response to this question. Few candidates were able to explain the purpose of the second decision with most just repeating the contents of the box rather than it being there to end the loop if the end of the list has been reached.

Question 20

Responses this were varied. Most were able to identify the input and the < symbol in the second and fourth spaces. Where candidates also knew guess for the third gap, they tended to identify 'if' for the first gap, rather than 'while'.

Question 21

Most popular responses were 'images', 'sound', 'video' and 'animation'. However, some incorrectly identified transitions and effects – these are not examples of content but features that can be applied to slides and content.

Question 22 (b)

Generally, this was answered well with most correctly identifying a type of alignment. Where candidates gave an incorrect response, they had identified a style applied to text such as bold or italics.

Question 23 (a)

Generally, well answered. However, it is important that candidates take more care to identify the part of the box – some circled a whole side, this is too general to be awarded the mark.

Question 23 (b)

Responses varied. Some candidates gave responses that were about organising documents in general and were not specific to the text box. Those that were able to relate it specifically to the text box tended to refer to MP1 and MP3 from the mark scheme. Fewer candidates referred to the ease of drawing attention to the text.

Question 26

Although candidates were able to suggest the file type should compress the image / reduce the file size to make sure the download is quicker, they were less able to identify the file type that would do this. Some identified graphic types – vector, or zip (a method of compressing).

Question 27(b)

If an example is given in the question stem and candidates are asked for one other, it is important that they don't repeat the example already given – this will not give them the mark. Many identified 'foreign key' as the difference, but this had already been given. After that most mentioned the number of tables. MP2 and MP4 was not seen at all.

Question 29

Many candidates were able to identify 'read (-only)' or 'view (-only)' as the file permission that would be used to share a file with a friend and not giving them the ability to edit it. Some candidates re-worded the question as their answer, rather than identify the specific permission.

Question 30 (b)

This was not answered well by candidates. They were unable to describe the purpose of the <head> tag, with many describing it as the tag that gave you a title or subtitle on the page to explain the contents of the page, rather than its actual purpose.

Question 31 (b)

Most candidates just said the data was text, rather than being specific that the data was not numeric and that is the reason why a graph cannot be created from the data in column A.

Question 31 (c)

Although candidates recognised the issues with the formula for the second part of the mark point. They did not specifically state the current formula would not give the correct result in their explanation. Candidates should consider the number of marks available for the response and make sure they have clearly identified why and then go onto explain why.

Question 32 (a)

Responses to this varied with many not correctly identifying the most appropriate choice of software.

Question 32 (b)

Many candidates were able to explain that consistency was important and that is why a house style is used for documents and therefore were awarded one mark. Some referred to both consistency and a professional look, fewer mentioned the brand identity. Where they had successfully identified the first part of the mark point, they also were able to identify the second part, gaining both marks.

Paper Summary

Based on their performance on this paper, students are offered the following advice:

- Expand and explain answers using examples and reasons, especially where more than a simple statement or list is requested
- Where a context or scenario is provided, respond with the context of the question in mind
- Read and interpret the question prompt to focus on the specific requirements and provide more relevant responses that address the critical aspects of the question.
- When required to give one other example/reason, ensure the response is discrete from the given example/reason

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